

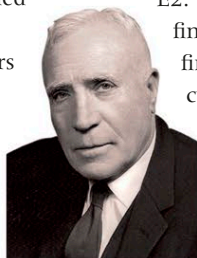
The Piper J3 Cub, the most famous of all the aircraft produced by Piper, in flight in 1944

Great Manufacturers Piper

William Piper was an oilman when he was persuaded to invest in a struggling aircraft company. Within a few short years, the company bore his name and his personal drive and commercial instinct had made the Cub the most popular aircraft of its era, establishing one of the world's great aircraft manufacturers.

Today the J3 Cub is remembered as the aircraft that made William T. Piper “the Henry Ford of aviation.”

However, the Cub was designed by C. Gilbert Taylor, who set up the original Taylor Brothers Aircraft Company with his brother, Gordon. Piper became an investor in the company when Gilbert moved the firm to Bradford, Pennsylvania in 1928 after the death of his brother Gordon in an air crash.



William T. Piper
(1881-1970)

The original E2 Cub appeared in 1930, the fifth in a series of Taylor aircraft that started with A, B, and C (“Chummy”) models—relatively expensive high-wing monoplanes that sold in tiny numbers. The E2 (“2” denoting two seats) was a product of the Depression. The Model D1 that

preceded it was a simple open-frame glider and, to keep costs down, its wing structure was used for the

E2. The biggest problem was finding a suitable engine. Taylor's first choice had been a two-cylinder, two-stroke: the 25 hp Brownbach Tiger Kitten.

This engine barely produced enough power to get the E2 off the ground, although legend has it that it gave the airplane its name, when Taylor Aircraft accountant

Gilbert Hadrel pointed out that a tiger's kitten is a cub.

Salvation arrived in the form of the Continental A-40, the flat-four (a flat engine with four cylinders) that set the pattern for light aircraft engines that has lasted to this day. However, the A-40 suffered early development problems and, while seeking alternative engine suppliers, Taylor designed and built the F2, G2, and H2 designations of the Cub.

The next model, the J2, introduced the rounded wing tips and tail surfaces, fully enclosed cabin, and raised rear fuselage line that are now so familiar. (There was no “I” model because the letter could easily be confused with the numeral “1”). The appearance of the J2 led to a big bust-up with far-reaching consequences: Piper had asked a young engineer called Walter Jamoneau to continue its development while Taylor was absent from work. This strained the already difficult relationship between Piper and Taylor and led to Taylor's resignation from the company in December 1935.



Piper PA-18 Super Cub

The PA-18 Super Cub's ability to get out of short, unprepared strips and carry improbable loads has made it the light utility aircraft of choice for pilots around the world.

Walter Jamoneau designed the next model, the J3, choosing not to use the logical K designation, instead changing the numeral to identify the new model, which remained a two-seater. The J3 was a runaway sales success, so much so that by 1941 60 percent of US civil light aircraft were Pipers.

In the 1940s the Cub went to war as the L-4, a lightly modified J3 with extended cockpit glazing and military radio that was used to direct artillery fire and for general liaison purposes. Seen as a kind of flying Jeep, the unarmed Cub proved to be a very effective weapon of war.

Like the other light aircraft manufacturers, Piper hoped to benefit from the large number of trained

pilots returning to civilian life after World War II. Indeed, sales reached record levels in 1946, when 7,782 airplanes were produced. However, the following year the bubble burst and Piper would have gone the same way as several of its competitors, but for the PA-15 Vagabond, acknowledged as “the airplane that saved Piper.” Retaining the Cub's A-65 engine, a little speed was gained (at the expense of short-field performance) by reducing the wingspan, and costs were brought down to the knuckle—Piper even going so far as to make the undercarriage rigid, relying on the tires to absorb landing shocks.

The “short-wing” Piper line was developed into the popular four-seat, tricycle-undercarriage PA-22 Tri-Pacer. In 1954, the company produced its first twin-engined and all-metal aircraft, the PA-23 Apache. This was followed by the high-performance, retractable-



An American aviation icon

This 1930s advertisement for the two-seater Piper Cub shows its famous “Cub Yellow” paint job. One of the most popular aircraft from its launch in 1937, many remain in use today.